



DCFS

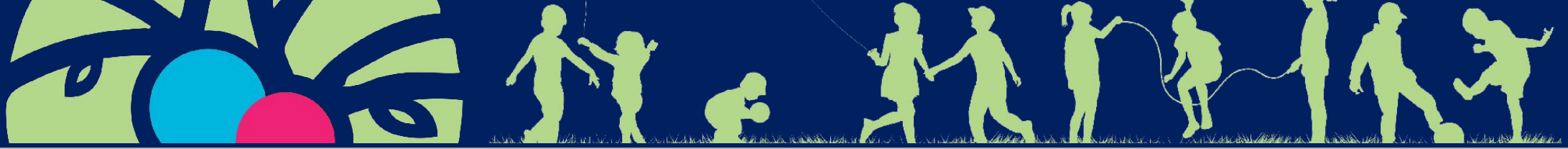
Illinois Department of
Children and Family Services

Transformation at DCFS

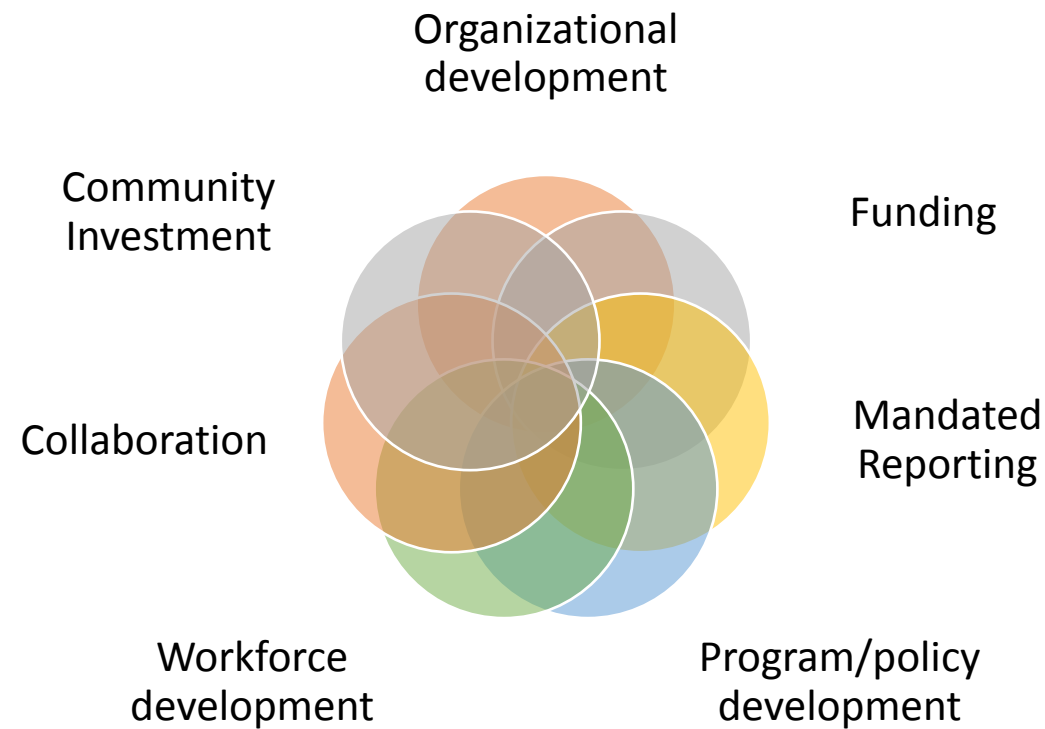
**Division of Prevention, Community Connection, and Intact Family
Services**

Division of Child Protection

8/20/26



Transformation through...





Right-sizing
the front
door

Family-Focused



Empowering
and equipping
our staff for
success

Integrity



Centering
our policies,
practices and
procedures on
what is best for
children, youth
and families

Respect



Better
supporting
children and
youth with
complex
medical and
healthcare
needs

Empathy



Ensuring
our children
and youth
transition
out of care
successfully

Equity

DCFS Mission

The Illinois Department of Children and Family Services (DCFS) promotes the safety and well-being of children, youth, and families by responding to reports of potential abuse and neglect and, when needed, providing family-centered care and connection to resources.

Vision

Every child and youth can grow and thrive in a family.

Is a child in immediate danger?

If you believe a child is in immediate danger,
that could result in death or serious harm

Call 911 FIRST



Are You Concerned about a Child or Family in Need, or do you Suspect Abuse or Neglect?

Making a report can have lasting impacts on families, especially when their needs could be better met through community support.
Review the Resources section below for helpful guidance before selecting "Make a report".

TIPS FOR MAKING A BETTER REPORT

1

Provide Specific Details

Share as many specific details as possible including dates, times, locations, and descriptions of observed incidents.

2

Focus on Facts, Not Assumptions

Avoid making assumptions or conclusions and instead focus on describing observable facts.

3

Describe Any Physical and Emotional Indicators

Note any physical signs (such as bruises, cuts, or other injuries) as well as emotional indicators (like fear, anxiety, or withdrawal) that may suggest abuse or neglect.

4

Share Relevant Family or Environmental Context

Mention any known family dynamic information, like how the adults and children function on a day-to-day basis.

[Make a Report](#)

REPORT NEGLECT



SUPPORT POVERTY-RELATED NEEDS



KNOW WHEN TO REPORT

KNOW HOW TO SUPPORT

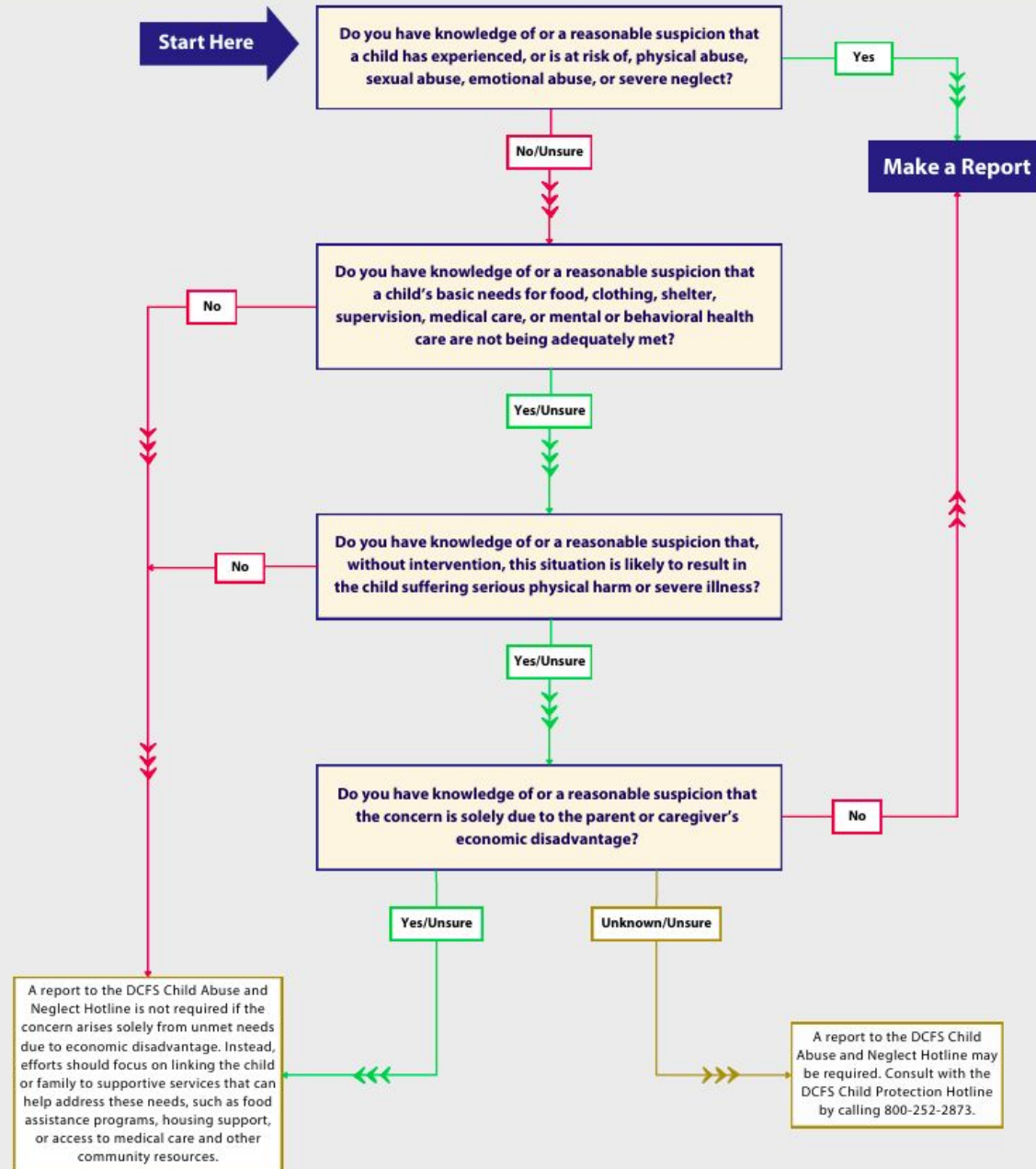
	EXAMPLES OF NEGLECT: Suspected neglect should always be reported.	EXAMPLES OF POVERTY-RELATED NEEDS:	HOW TO SUPPORT POVERTY-RELATED NEEDS:
 BASIC NEEDS FOOD & SHELTER	- Child consistently goes without food for long periods. - Unsafe or unsanitary living conditions that are life-threatening. - Intentional refusal to provide shelter.	- Family lacks money to buy sufficient food for the month. - Temporary homelessness due to job loss. - Inadequate housing caused by financial struggles.	Connect family to food pantries, rental assistance programs, and housing resources.
 CLOTHING	Child lacks appropriate clothing for severe weather (e.g., winter coat during freezing conditions).	Family cannot afford new clothes or shoes due to limited finances.	Refer to community donation programs or clothing drives.
 MEDICAL CARE	- Caregiver refuses necessary medical care for a serious illness or injury. - Consistent failure to seek treatment for life-threatening conditions.	- Family cannot afford insurance or transportation to access medical care. - Missed appointments due to work schedule or childcare issues.	Connect family to Medicaid, local clinics, or transportation assistance programs.
 SUPERVISION	- Young child left alone for extended periods without care. - Intentional lack of supervision placing the child in danger (e.g., near open flames or unsafe areas).	- Parent is working multiple jobs or lacks childcare support. - Child occasionally left alone briefly due to work constraints.	Refer to affordable childcare resources or family support programs.
 EDUCATION	- Caregiver consistently prevents a child from attending school. - Refusal to address educational neglect or truancy.	- Lack of internet, technology, or supplies needed for schooling. - Inability to afford school fees or transportation.	Offer referrals for educational assistance programs or school support services.

SUPPORT POVERTY-RELATED NEEDS	
KNOW HOW TO SUPPORT	
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DRAFT

REPORTER DECISION TREE

Use this decision tree to help decide if a Child Abuse or Neglect report should be made or if there are better options like connecting a family to community resources.



Calling the DCFS Hotline



Hotline

Report

Report of
Suspected
Abuse or
Neglect

Information
Only

No Report
Taken

Support

Community
Connections

Extended
Family
Support
Program

Dependency

Family
Advocacy
Centers

200,000+

hotline contacts
each year in Illinois

A reflection of how much Illinois communities care about children.

70%+

of investigated families
result in unfounded findings

Most families were subjected to the weight of a formal investigation without a finding to justify it.

Community Connections

- Families deflected from Intake/Hotline where there is a service need or prior history, but no suspected abuse or neglect
- Help stabilize the family environment and prevent the need for a child protection investigation
- [Community Connections Brochure](#)



Community Connections

- Goals
 - Assess the family's service needs and link to available local community resources;
 - Promote the family's well-being;
 - Support families in addressing identified challenges and needs; and
 - Equip families to effectively utilize their own strengths and community resources.

MY FAMILY SELF-ASSESSMENT

Supported by: DCFS Office of Community Connection



Name: _____ Date: _____

About Me:

Gender/Pronouns	DOB
Address	
City, State, Zip	
Phone	
Email Address	

My Household:

Name	Relationship	Phone

My Children:

Name	DOB (or Due Date)	Living With	Contact Phone

Services Our Family is Currently Using:

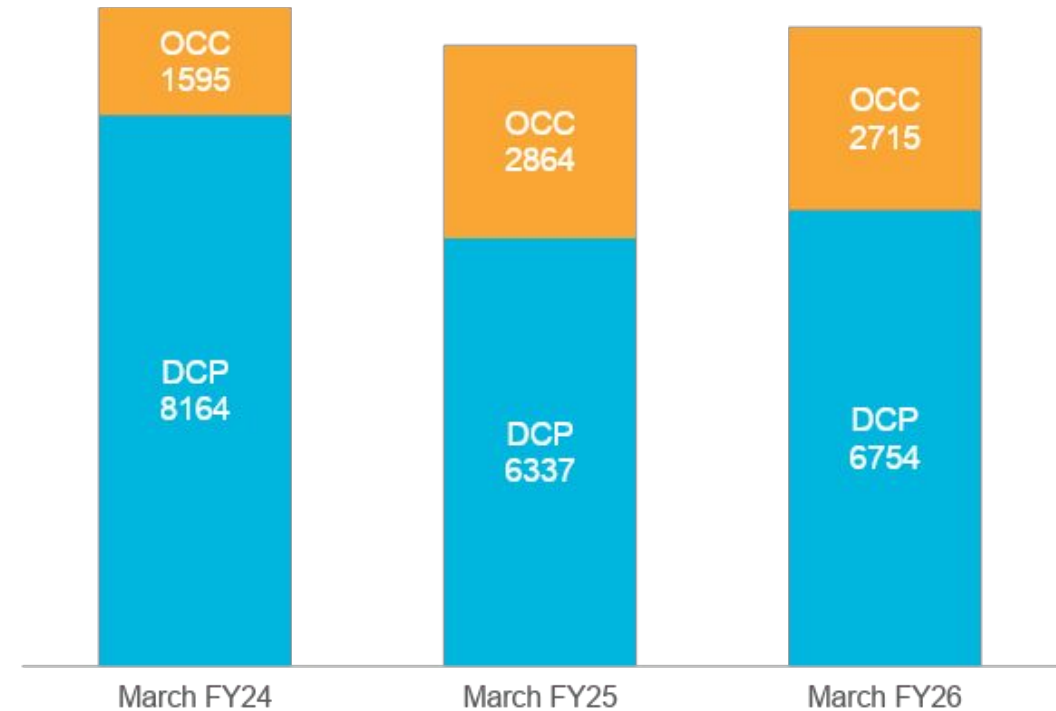
Household Member	Service Name	Provider/Agency Name	Service Description	How Often/Long?

Who/What Supports Our Family?

Community Connections and the Pillar

Right-sizing
the front door

SCR intakes



Advisory groups

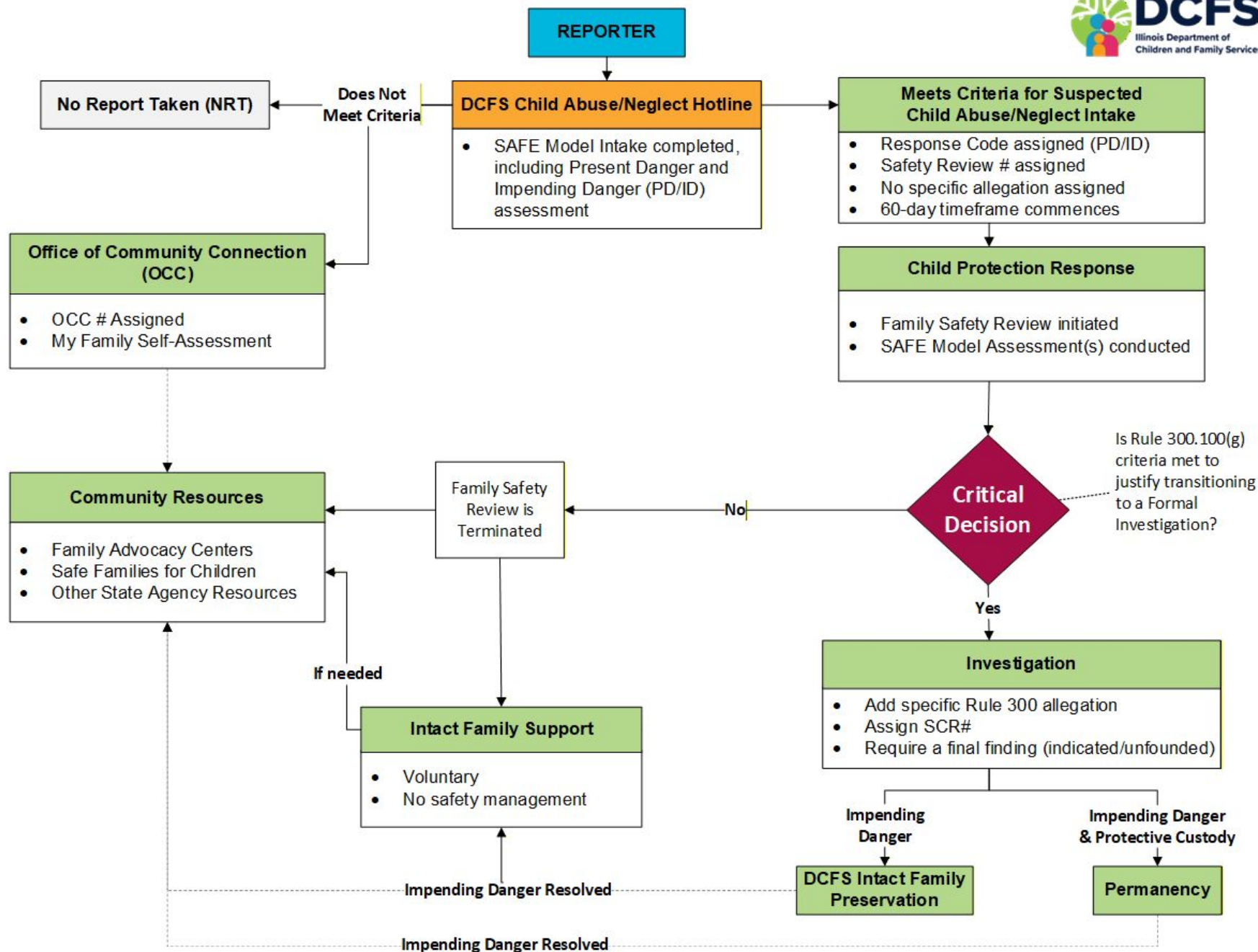
- Process
- Language

Paid Parent Partners

- Policy
- Scripts
- Training curricula



Forward Together Family Case Flow Chart



Pathways for Families after Child Protection Response



Family Support

- Families with no danger identified
- Voluntary — family chooses whether to engage
- Light-touch, non-surveillance support
- Contracted community agencies provides DCFS-funded services
- No compliance monitoring. No reporting back on family behavior.
- Goal: connect families to resources they want and need to achieve their goals



Family Preservation

- Families where danger exists and a formal safety plan is required
- Mandatory engagement — family must participate
- Active safety planning, monitoring, and compliance oversight
- DCFS workers provide services
- Goal: resolve danger, prevent removal, build family protective capacity

QUESTIONS?

